

TOTEMTOU × PALGA RINPOCHE

Upper Mustang

Distribution Strategy

How we sell the recce seats now, and the March 2027 founding journey next

Team alignment document · v1 · 24 September 2026

Prepared by Swapnil for the recce team: Rinpoche, Eksha, Rahul, Vikas, Deepak

1. The strategy in one picture

We are selling **two different things to two different audiences**, and keeping them separate is the whole game. Confusing them is how we cheapen the premium trip or fail to fill the recce.

	JOB 1: Fill the recce	JOB 2: Sell March 2027
What	8 seats on this year's 14-day recce	The founding journey, ~\$11,888/guest
Why	Cost recovery + proof + content	The real product and the real margin
Who buys	Our personal & inner networks	Partners' audiences (Zostel, Wanderon, HST)
How	Warm, quiet, direct: PDF + WhatsApp + private link	Partner distribution deals, seeded now
Price	\$3,499 with bike · \$2,899 without	~\$11,888 (to confirm)
Timing	Sell now	Sell across the season into March 2027

The one rule to hold

The recce price (\$3,499 / \$2,899) stays with our own network and OFF every public channel.

Broadcasting a cheap Himalayan-monk trip today makes the ~\$11,888 March trip harder to sell later.

Recce = quiet, warm, scarce, at cost. March = loud, public, premium, global.

2. Products & prices (single source of truth)

Everyone quoting numbers should quote these. Anything still being finalised is flagged.

Item	Price	Notes
Recce seat, with bike	\$3,499	Guest rides part of the route on the spare Enfield
Recce seat, without bike	\$2,899	Guest travels in the 4x4s
March 2027 founding seat	~\$11,888	To confirm what it includes before it goes in any partner doc
Recce cost recovery	Break-even $\approx$ 5.5 seats	Full trip cost ~\$18.3k (6) to ~\$20.8k (8); seats above that build buffer

Open cost items still being finalised ($\approx$ 24 hrs): drone permit (CAAN), group insurance / evacuation, comms (SIM + satellite), oxygen + medkit, monastery offerings, Kathmandu–Pokhara transfers, Rinpoche's honorarium, weather-extension buffer. These are covered by the per-seat buffer from $\sim$ 7 seats up; the two that could move the number are the honorarium and weather days.

3. The recce: team, vehicles & capacity

14 days / 13 nights · Pokhara ↔ Lo Manthang loop · bike + 4x4 mixed mode · max altitude 3,840m at Lo Manthang.

Core team (8)

Rinpoche · Eksha · Rahul · Swapnil · Vikas · Deepak (Nepali licensed guide) · photographer/cameraman · mechanic/rider.

Fleet & seats

Vehicle	Seats	Core allocation
3 personal bikes	1 each	Rinpoche, Eksha, Rahul
Rented Enfield (spare)	1	Free; one guest can ride
Swapnil's car (Skoda Kylaq)	5	Swapnil, cameraman, Vikas → 2 free
Rahul's Isuzu 4x4	5	Deepak, rider/mechanic → 3 free
Rented Bolero 4x4 (+driver)	5	Driver takes 1 → up to 4 free

What this means for seats

Free car seats: 9–10 (the Bolero driver may take one). That comfortably seats 8 guests.

Only ONE guest can ride, on the spare Enfield. Each extra rider = another ~\$600 Enfield.

So: sell bike seats as 'limited, first to confirm', or we end up with six riders and one bike.

Foreign guests are fine on price: Upper Mustang permits are \$50/day for foreigners too, same as SAARC.

4. Job 1: Fill the recce seats (personal network)

This is not a reach problem. We need **8 committed humans, not 8,000 impressions**. Rinpoche's inner circle alone can oversell it. Work it warm and direct.

The channels

- **Rinpoche's inner circle, our #1 source.** A private message to 15–25 people he'd personally want on a recce. His hand-pick plus real scarcity converts far above a public post.
- **Eksha (~500k followers).** Via DM / Close Friends, not the public grid. Ask her to hand-pick and message ~20 serious contacts. Protects the price anchor and self-selects.
- **Our personal networks.** Direct asks, not posts. The 'deeper end' we're counting on.
- **Fabio (Brazil).** 10+ countries riding, strong international network. Because foreign permits are also \$50/day, his people can actually buy recce seats, not just awareness. Frame it as 'this one or the next'.

The distribution kit (per person)

1. **A personalised invitation PDF** that opens with a note from Rinpoche himself, addressed to the recipient, naming the core of the trip and what they can expect: a personal invitation to the expedition, not a brochure.
2. **A short WhatsApp message** for the sender to forward, carrying the PDF and a link.
3. **A single-page landing page** the link opens: the story, then a payment option at the end. The same link sits as a CTA on the last page of the PDF.

Mechanics that actually close seats

- **Keep the landing page unlisted** and hidden from search engines, so the price stays off the public web.
- **Give each person their own link** (e.g. ?ref=eksha, ?ref=rinpoche) so we know which network filled seats, useful for the partner proposals too.
- **Take a deposit first** (e.g. ₹50k / \$600) to hold a seat, balance by a set date. Razorpay for INR, Stripe/PayPal for foreign cards (Fabio's people can't use UPI).
- **Put three things above the pay button:** this is a recce and the route may change; an altitude & fitness note (3,840m); mandatory insurance. On record now saves arguments at Kagbeni.
- **Oversell into a waitlist.** Expect 30–40% of 'yeses' to melt before deposit.

5. Job 2: Partner distribution (March 2027)

Partners do not fill the recce. They distribute the **March 2027 founding journey** to their audiences. The recce is our proof: we pitch partners after it's confirmed, and give at most 1–2 of them a seat on it (at the standard price) to learn and film the product.

What every partner gets

- **The product:** 14 days in Upper Mustang with Palga Rinpoche, where the ride itself is the practice. Spiritual + wellness + adventure in one trip, with no direct competitor.
- **The teacher:** 'the monk who sold his Maserati', with reach beyond Instagram, including The Ranveer Show.
- **The place:** a permit-capped restricted kingdom, closed to outsiders until 1992, scarce by law, impossible to copy.
- **The proof:** recce route data, photography, video and first guest stories they can use in their own marketing.
- **The upside:** Rinpoche plans 8+ journeys a year across Ladakh, Nepal, Uttarakhand and Lahaul. Joining at the flagship earns first right on the calendar that follows.

Zostel: Totemtou's spiritual collection

Pitch (from Totemtou alone): a ready-made spiritual & meditative collection, the Rinpoche edition as flagship, with Totemtou retreats in **Chamba, Shimla and Dehradun** underneath it.

- The CEO already wants a spiritual/meditative vertical; Zo Trips has none today. We bring a launch, not an idea.
- Flagship makes the collection feel serious; the three India retreats bring the volume (Zo prices top out ~₹1.4L, vs an ₹11.4L flagship).
- Zostel role: sell, refer, host retreats where a property fits. Money: commission on everything it sells, flagship and retreats.
- We need: a named owner, launch dates for the three retreats, and a flagship slot in app + newsletter before March 2027.

Wanderon: content seat + distribution

- Raised ₹54 crore (~\$5.9M) Series A (Jan 2026), scaling adventure and **wellness** travel; sells Northern Lights & F1 trips, so a ~\$11,900 trip fits its audience.
- Deal: one creator buys a recce seat, films it, and Wanderon features the March trip to its community. First option on future co-branded departures.
- Money: commission on March seats, and on future trips it sells. Pitch to Govind Gaur (CEO) or the wellness lead.

Himalayan Single Track: co-ownership

- **Pitch:** HST co-owns the March edition as its entry into moto: a flagship expedition for its existing high-value, mostly-foreign clients, with no operational work on its side.
- HST runs MTB from Kathmandu (40+ nationalities, 200+ 5-star reviews) and its own Upper Mustang Enduro. Co-owning turns a possible competitor into a partner. (Note: HST may not provide motorbikes; this is their way in, not a supply role.)
- We need: a place on HST's website, socials and newsletters, plus personal outreach to fitting clients.
- HST is selling something new to them, so the proposal must explain the product: who Rinpoche is, his podcasts (incl. The Ranveer Show), his viewpoint (the ride as practice), what a day looks like, and recce footage as proof.
- Money: a co-owner revenue share on March seats; split still to agree.

6. Terms at a glance

	Zostel	Wanderon	Himalayan Single Track
Deal type	Vertical launch	Content + distribution	Co-ownership + distribution
Their audience	Budget backpackers, India	Young premium, India	International riders, 40+ countries
Main ask	Flagship + Chamba, Shimla, Dehradun retreats	Feature March to their community	Website, socials, newsletters, personal outreach
Recce seat	1, content/trip lead, \$2,899	1 creator, \$2,899	1 guide, optional, \$3,499 w/ bike
Share of March seats	10–15% (proposed)	10–15% (proposed)	Co-owner revenue share (to agree)
Other money	Commission on retreats	Commission on future trips	None
Expected March seats	0–1	1–2	1–3

Seat expectations are our estimates, not partner commitments. Partner recce seats are priced like any guest seat: \$2,899 without a bike, \$3,499 with one. Every partner conversation starts through someone in our network and continues by email.

7. The tension to manage

Every 'loud' channel that sells a cheap Himalayan-monk trip today makes the ~\$11,888 March trip harder to sell.

So the influencers' and operators' REACH points at March; their INNER CIRCLES fill the recce.

Recce = quiet, warm, scarce, at cost. March = loud, public, premium, global.